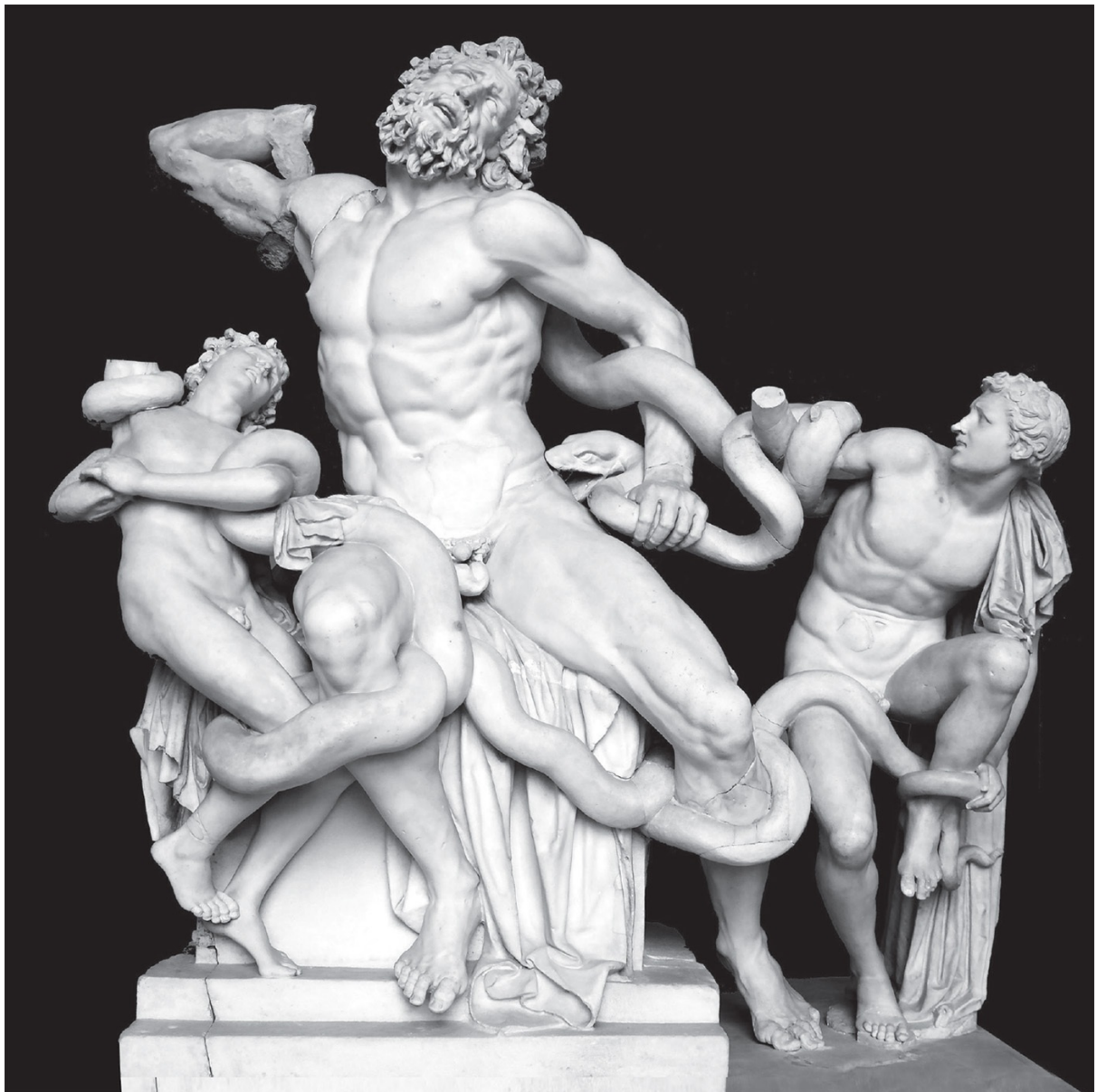


Hellenistic sculpture

During the Hellenistic period that began under Alexander the Great (336–323 BCE), Greece transformed into a cosmopolitan culture spreading across the eastern Mediterranean and south-west Asia. Greek became the official language of the Hellenistic world, and the art and literature also changed: abandoning the previous preoccupation with idealism, Hellenistic art focused on realism, characterized by emotion and illusionistic effects.

While sculpture still depicted noble figures, naturalism spread to representations of common people, women, children and animals. Domestic scenes became acceptable subjects for reliefs. Realistic portraits of men and women were produced, and dynamic works including *The Dying Gaul* (c.220 BCE), the *Winged Victory of Samothrace* (c.195 BCE), *Laocoön and his Sons*, first century BCE, and *Aphrodite of Milos*, or *Venus de Milo*, c.130–100 BCE. All these statues depict Classical themes, but in more sensuous, naturalistic, theatrical and emotional representations than had been created in the Classical period.



Laocoön and his Sons, first century BCE